

bourhoods. It is only among the Victorianised middle class that all this 'exposure' and 'early' sexual activity is new," she says.

RISKY BUSINESS

Discovering the opposite sex

Children are becoming aware of their sexuality much before the requisite age. Girls giggle and skip a heartbeat at the very sight of the footballer from senior school. Having a crush on a boy your age is "just so lame", says Delhi's Ananyai Bhaan, 11. Half the lunch-hour is spent in the washroom, re-applying the kohl and the lip-gloss and the other half in passing the said crush again and again, to make sure he is watching. What if he smiles back? A slumber party is thrown to honour the smile, where the polka-dotted pyja-

mas and Garfield tees have been replaced by lacy knickers and satin slips. The night is spent imitating looks from fashion magazines and discussing the move from a sports bra to a regular one. "My friend Inayat

SPEED BUMPS AHEAD:
PRE-TEENS TODAY ARE
GROWING UP FAST,
PHYSICALLY AND MENTALLY

and I paint each other's nails and watch tv till late in the night. We also discuss how cute Aamir Khan is and gossip about who has a crush on whom," says Akriti Sahrawat, 10, also from Delhi. Chick flicks are watched back-to-back and ginger-ales are sipped while reputations are torn apart. Being

last in the annual academic list is nothing compared to the trauma of being last in the annual cool list.

Boys are no less. They might not thrive on gossip but they have to be up-to-date on the latest, from the location of the shop that has the ultimate collection of porn movies to the one that sells *Penthouse* covered as *Hardy Boys*. There are ego problems and cutthroat competition. Who is the 'Bond' of the school? Who hangs out with the big bad boys? Who has a high-tech watch, an iMac and a BlackBerry? Who drives a car already? And who can steal liquor from his dad's cabinet? From smooth talking with the girls to slime talking with men. The more the number of unacceptably uncouth words in your vocabulary bigger the

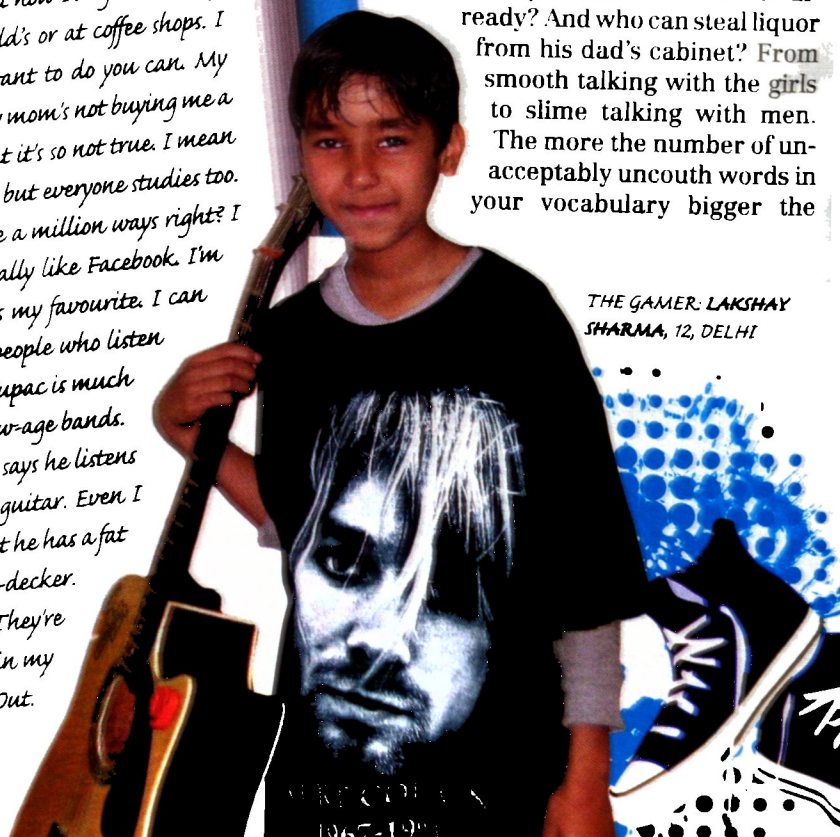
Photograph by HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com; Location courtesy INTERCONTINENTAL EROS, "Eros" Model (left to right) SEAJ ANSHIKA ABHI SHRI & MAYANK. Girl Model Management. Makeup by SARITA



Dear Diary,

I am a little confused. I'm a seventh grader who loves to play video games the most. I think they're really awesome. I mean I used to play a bit of cricket with my friends when I was a kid but now I've grown out of it. I hang out most with my friends at McDonald's or at coffee shops. I think it's best to go to a mall. Whatever you want to do you can. My favourite video games are obviously PS1, 2 & 3. My mom's not buying me a PS4 yet. She said I don't study because of that but it's so not true. I mean I'll obviously study, right? Besides everyone plays but everyone studies too. Besides, if I really don't want to study there are a million ways right? I can spend my time on the Internet. I don't really like Facebook. I'm just on it because everyone's on it. YouTube is my favourite. I can watch all the music videos I feel like. I hate people who listen to Eminem in the name of hip-hop. I think Tupac is much better. I even like rock music. But not the new-age bands. I like proper rock like Metallica. My brother says he listens to rock but he listens to blues. He plays the guitar. Even I want to learn to play. He looks really cool. But he has a fat girlfriend. My friends and I call her a double-decker. Maybe she's nice but, I don't like girls at all. They're just weird. My friends think there's a girl in my class who likes me. I don't think so. Peace Out.

Lakshay



THE GAMER: LAKSHAY SHARMA, 12, DELHI